Maritime kingdoms on India's Malabar and Coromandel coasts maintained flourishing seaborne commerce with South-East Asia and China.

The Ming dynasty (1368–1644): This was a restoration of a Han dynasty. Zheng He's voyages into the Indian Ocean, the Gulf and East Africa took place under the Ming, but were later discontinued.

The Delhi Sultanate was ruled successively by the Sayyid (1141–1450 CE) and then the Lodi (1451–1526) dynasties. The Mughal empire in India was founded by Babur in 1526. The Vijayanagar empire was established in the south in 1336 CE and eventually covered virtually the whole peninsula by the sixteenth century. The empire declined after its defeat by a confederation of Deccan sultanates in 1526 and ceased to exist in 1646. The Deccan sultanates continued to rule till 1688.

The Qing dynasty (1644–1912): A non-Han, Manchu dynasty, its early phase corresponding to the Mughal dynasty in India up to the formal establishment of the British empire in India in 1858. The empire weakened under serial peasant revolts, and later under attacks by foreign powers.

The British used Indian troops to defeat the Qing in the Opium Wars of 1839–42 and 1856–60. The Qing empire came to an end in 1912 with the abdication of the last emperor. A republic was proclaimed, but the country descended into civil war.

In India, the Indian National Congress was established in 1885.

The Republic of China (1912–49): This began with a period of warlordism in China, with the country split into various fragments ruled by regional strongmen. The First World War broke out in Europe. China declared itself an ally of the European powers. The Russian Revolution took place in 1917 and had a major influence on China. The end of the war saw Chinese expectations of the end of its semi-colonial status belied. Japan continued to be aggressive. The May Fourth Movement broke out in Beijing among university students in 1919.

China was again unified under the Guomindang (KMT) General Chiang Kai-shek in 1927, but Japan invaded China, occupying Manchuria. The Communist Party of China (CPC) was established in 1921 in Shanghai and collaborated with the KMT, but a split occurred in 1927.